

A/An vs The

CEFR A2

Lesson Pack · summary, worksheet & answer key

Quick answer

Both come before nouns; the difference is whether the listener knows which one:

- 1 a/an — new or non-specific, one of many (I bought a book).
- 2 the — specific and known to the listener (The book was brilliant).

Typical flow: first mention with a/an, then 'the' afterwards. Use 'the' whenever the listener can identify exactly which one.

At a glance

	a/an	the
Meaning	new / non-specific	specific / known
Listener knows which one?	no	yes
Example	I need a chair.	Sit on the chair by the window.
First vs second mention	first mention	after that

Learning objectives

- Can choose between a/an (indefinite) and the (definite) by whether the noun is known (CEFR A2).
- Can use the first-mention → second-mention pattern (a/an → the).
- Can use 'the' for unique or context-defined nouns on first mention.

Practice worksheet

Circle the correct option. A/An vs The · CEFR A2

Name: _____

Date: _____

1. I saw ____ film last night. ____ film was brilliant.

A. a / The

B. the / A

C. a / A

D. the / The

2. Could you pass me ____ salt? (it's on the table)

A. the

B. a

C. an

D. —

3. I'm looking for ____ job. (any job)

A. a

B. the

C. an

D. —

4. She's ____ architect. She designed ____ new library in town.

A. an / the

B. the / a

C. a / the

D. an / a

5. Let's watch ____ sunset from the hill.

A. the

B. a

C. an

D. —

6. There's ____ message and ____ parcel for you. ____ parcel looks heavy.

A. a / a / The

B. the / the / A

C. a / a / A

D. the / a / The

7. Close ____ window, please. It's cold.

A. the

B. a

C. an

D. —

8. Correct this: 'I bought a car. A car is red.'

A. I bought a car. The car is red.

B. I bought the car. A car is red.

C. I bought a car. A car is red.

D. I bought the car. The car is red.

9. We climbed ____ mountain. ____ view from the top was amazing.

A. a / The

B. the / A

C. a / A

D. an / The

10. How do you choose between a/an and the?

A. the if the listener knows which one; a/an if it's new or non-specific.

B. a/an for specific things; the for general things.

C. the for first mention; a/an afterwards.

D. a/an for unique things like the sun.

Answer key

Correct answers with explanations · for the teacher

1. **A. a / The** — First mention 'a film', then known 'The film'.
2. **A. the** — Both know which salt: 'the salt'.
3. **A. a** — Any non-specific job: 'a job'.
4. **A. an / the** — Job 'an architect'; specific building 'the new library'.
5. **A. the** — The one happening now is specific: 'the sunset'.
6. **A. a / a / The** — Two new items 'a message', 'a parcel'; then known 'The parcel'.
7. **A. the** — The window here is obvious and specific: 'the window'.
8. **A. I bought a car. The car is red.** — Second mention is now known: 'The car is red'.
9. **A. a / The** — New 'a mountain'; then specific 'The view'.
10. **A. the if the listener knows which one; a/an if it's new or non-specific.** — Known/specific → the; new/non-specific → a/an.